

WEEK 14 · RELATIONALITY AND TYING IT ALL TOGETHER

## CLASS 1

# Who Are Children to Each Other?

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### READING 1

Excerpts from the Introduction (pp. 1–7) and “Chapter 1: Re-forming Lives” (pp. 26–49) in *Inhabiting “Childhood”* – Balagopalan

# **Inhabiting "Childhood": Children, Labour and Schooling in Postcolonial India | Balagopalan**

Week 14, Class 1

Introduction — pp. 1–7

Chapter 1: Re-forming Lives: The Child on the Street and the "Street Child" — pp. 26–49

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# Introduction

On that hot summer afternoon as I walked down busy Chowringhee Road, the large billboard had caught my eye. It was a message from the police, implicitly addressed to the city's literate and civic-minded residents. Any child 5–10 years of age found on the street during school hours should be brought to the nearest police station. Given that for even such privileged residents actual contact with the police or the legal system had historically been an ambivalent and somewhat reluctant event, the billboard was unusual. It looked as if it indicated the beginning of a new urban temperament in which the police and the bourgeois middle class were reinventing their relationship in an idiom of civic-minded camaraderie. In this new idiom, one could also temporarily forget that street and working children have particularly tense and difficult relations with the police. As the billboard spelt out, the matter was now a simple one: it was public service to help truant poor children by bringing them to the police station. Of course, alternative policing of poor children – away from the usual blunt punitive practices – had some presence in Calcutta.<sup>1</sup> Since 1999, several of the city's police stations had begun to house an alternative education programme that targeted working children from adjoining slums. However, such initiatives only worked within the confines of these poorer neighbourhoods. Being local initiatives, they did not – unlike the proposal advertised on the billboard – address the rest of the city and its literate public sphere as their audience.

A more plausible explanation for the police billboard lay in an initiative that had gained much kudos with the city's middle-class residents three years earlier. Beginning in 1999, the Calcutta Municipal Corporation had undertaken a citywide programme to enrol all out-of-school children in the city's government-run schools, including making efforts to set up new schools and train new teachers. As the first comprehensive

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urban initiative of its kind in India, it marked a radical shift in the ways the futures of out-of-school or working children were being imagined. This initiative in Calcutta signalled a fundamental recasting of official discourse on the most useful trajectory for labouring children. No longer were such children to be abandoned to the logic of 'child labour' in the informal economy, rather they were to be offered up to their 'natural' location in the school. Within this more urgent imperative to universalize formal schooling in the city, the police, as revealed by the signboard, were being paradoxically cast in the role of a crucial and benign facilitator.

Ten years later, by 2009, this small eruption of urgency had culminated in the monumental passing of a national law that made elementary education free and compulsory. A decade in the making, this law is widely viewed as allowing all children in India to realize opportunities through access to schooling, which has been unavailable in their lives till now. Coinciding with its emergence as an important force in the global scale of things, the Indian nation-state has felt an enormous compulsion to recalibrate the lives of poor children in order to prove its claim to globality. There is constant anxiety related to India's 'arrival' on the global economic stage. The country's reputation as a rising economic powerhouse is propelled by its phenomenal growth in the international IT and biotech sectors, with the educational excellence and savvy of its professionals and entrepreneurs highlighted in the media. But this focus on the success of India's knowledge workers has also brought a greater and uncomfortable visibility to the large population of uneducated masses and their stunning poverty, the so-called 'real' India that vividly discloses the deceptive foothold of the nation's economic success. Post-liberalization India continues to have the dubious distinction of the world's highest number of working children despite the six-decade old Indian constitution explicitly expressing a desire to make elementary education compulsory (Naik, 1975; Weiner, 1991). Even though government schools did not formally restrict access, a range of factors, including cost of schooling, cumbersome admission procedures, the need for children to work to supplement family incomes and the lack of adequate school spaces, had worked to effectively foreclose children's universal enrolment and retention. Now, through the passing of the Right to Education Act (2009), the Indian state is signalling its commitment towards ensuring that each child receives quality schooling.

The pressing claim of this legislation is not only about the question of education in each child's life but also about what it implies – as a cumulative effect of all children in school – for the contemporary nation at large. As a crucial modern civilizational milestone, the separation of the

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child from labour through compulsory schooling takes on an immense urgency, and the present moment of making elementary education available to all is the most vivid sign of this modernization. The current broad-based resoluteness in securing elementary education for all is strongly shared by the state and the nation's ruling classes, the country's media networks, corporate networks and an active citizenry. This law, then, is caught up in broader affects of arrival and anxiety. Projecting the image of a state finally working towards compulsory schooling in the hope that it will put an end to child labour is a central part of this management of being and becoming a global player. The sign outside the Calcutta UNICEF office that reads 'Let all children be school goers and there will be no child labour' reveals the insistent anticipation of this new moment in postcolonial India. As part of a



*Figure 1* The sign outside the Calcutta UNICEF office.

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new discourse of those who are 'out of school', the lives of millions of children nationwide are now differently marked, no longer as 'child labour' but rather as an epic journey from being 'out of school' to the promised domain of 'free and compulsory education'.

At this critical juncture, when the nation narrates itself through this anticipated fulfilment of its promise of universal elementary education, this book steps back in time to read this assurance against the dense complexity of two related forms of marginalized children's lives: a group of street children in Calcutta and a heterogeneous range of historical and contemporary sites in modern India where children are engaged in capitalist production and labour. These forms are overwhelmingly dominant, wherein poor children inhabit the history of capitalism in India. Yet, given the anxiety of consolidating and securing the narrative of arrival, the current Indian middle classes and the associated national and media publics seek to inflect these extensive forms of 'childhoods' as a receding past. But the robust persistence of these forms points to the complexity and contemporaneity of extensive everyday practices of dwelling that have emerged as the necessary supplement to the fact of these children being 'out of school'. The tenacity of this weave interrupts the narrative of transition from labour to school in these children's lives. Their inability to seamlessly be part of school enrolment efforts indicates that the assumed predictability of the transition from labour to schooling is less than obvious; it is this elementary tension that this book seeks to explore.

The fact that this tension is part of a more internationally driven humanist intent with regard to 'children's rights' introduces an added dimension to the discussion. The near unanimous global ratification of the United Nation's Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) during the 1990s brought intense focus on the marginal child in the non-west. This child became both an object of humanitarian concern as well as agential through the global recognition of its 'rights'. The UNCRC phenomenally expanded the global focus on children, institutionalizing not only a new vocabulary to represent these lives but also an international network of funding and policy-setting, whose axis of influence began to govern national-domestic agendas as well. From the mid-nineties onwards, NGOs in India developed a growing awareness of this new language of children's rights. Trickling in through global campaigns and funding that increasingly mobilized NGOs to adopt this discourse, the language of children's rights gradually became naturalized in the work with marginal children. The capacious and uncritical acceptance gained by this new language of children's rights was evident in the Indian

government establishing a National Commission for the Protection of Children's Rights in 2007 as well as when the country's prominent children's NGO 'Child Relief and You' (CRY) decisively changed its name to 'Child Rights and You' in 2006 (*The Hindu*, 10 April 2006).

## Rights and rescue

I first became aware of the weight of this new language of children's rights towards the end of my doctoral fieldwork with street children living in a crowded railway station in Calcutta. Platform Number 10 at Sealdah's South Station housed an NGO shelter for street kids, and I had often visited this site since 1990. Started in 1989 by CINI-ASHA, the urban wing of a prominent rural NGO in West Bengal, this shelter for boys consisted of two tin sheds at the end of the railway platform and was popularly referred to as the 'platform school'. Children who were part of this 'school' were from the south-eastern districts of West Bengal, particularly South 24 Parganas, and from neighbouring Bangladesh. As one of the main commuter arteries to the city, Sealdah's South Station was used daily by multitudes of rural women employed as domestic servants in the city's middle-class homes. The Kole Market nearby, the wholesale hub for vegetables and fish, additionally attracted hundreds of small farmers from South 24 Parganas who also came in daily to sell their goods. This regular commuter traffic, along with families who had made the station their temporary home, represented a microcosm of the rural dispossessed who increasingly travelled to the city in search of work. The children at Sealdah were part of this distress migration at the rural-urban interface, whose increase over the past twenty years had ironically coincided with the rule of the Communist Party or the CPI (M) in the state of West Bengal (Roy, 2003). The Left Front, which was voted out of power in 2011, had been well known for its agrarian reform, including a critical initiative of redistributing land to landless farmers. But with the advent of economic liberalization in India in the late eighties, a dominant section of the party had shifted gears towards urban renewal, with Calcutta being intensely recast as an urban dream-scape, a possible 'Paris of the East'. This moment of urban developmentalism in Calcutta coincided with the increased domestication of discourses on 'care and protection' of marginalized children, which had begun to circulate in the early nineties. Sealdah Station's 'platform school' was an embodiment of this concern. Within its four walls a new regime of optimism and children's rights began to gather itself. Replacing the dynamics of distress, this new assemblage started to recalibrate the boys' lives.



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*Figure 2* This shelter for boys consisted of two tin sheds at the end of the railway platform.

This book explores the tensions involved in this recalibration and is a marked departure from more traditional ethnographies of street children. Several of these have evocatively studied the creative dwelling of children in varied and hostile urban circumstances in different cities of the world (Aptekar, 1988; Burr, 2006; Davies, 2008; Hecht, 1998; Kovats-Bernat 2006; Swart, 1990). More recent efforts to improve the lives of this population through the global circulation of a new sentimentality around the figure of the street child have also been critically interrogated in terms of their deployment by NGOs and the state (Manzo, 2008; Nieuwenhuys, 2001; White, 1999, 2002). The specific circulation of school enrolment as the most critical of children's rights and the elementary tension in marginal children being unable to make real its promise foreground a complex range of issues that exceeds the immediate lives of the children at Sealdah. The most crucial issue is being able to locate the common sense of labour in these lives within the longer story of colonial and postcolonial modernity, highlighting the



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imperative to work on the lives of those who inhabit the economy's margins.

This book investigates the current approach to marginal children's lives in the non-west in order to both attend to the disjunct I witnessed between the platform and the 'platform school' at Sealdah and to employ it as a recent historical counterpoint to this moment of certainty about being on track to eliminate child labour through education – not to disagree with what this moment proposes but to use it to reflect on the continuing predicaments of the past. To what extent does this present moment of 'urgency' related to reforming the lives of marginalized children in the non-west reflect a larger global politics of 'victimhood'? How has the discipline of 'childhood studies' intellectually engaged the diversity of children's lives across the globe, while keeping in mind the hegemonic circulation of the singular framing of an ideal childhood within global policy discourse? Conceptually, what might a framing of children's lives in the non-west in the context of colonial/postcolonial modernity add to the current framework of 'multiple childhoods'? Given that as subjects of the ethnographic gaze marginalized children in the non-west are usually marked by their 'resilience', while international policy discourse signals their 'victimhood', how might we read this binary in conjunction with the increased anxieties around safety and sexual abuse that currently frame children's lives in the modern west?

I address the aforementioned questions in this Introduction neither to reiterate nor to offer a synoptic rendition of what has already been more than well articulated in the two-decade-old existence of 'childhood studies' as a discipline. Instead, I try to engage what seems to me to be a continuing tension within this field, namely, the ambiguity that endures around framing the lives of marginalized children in the non-west. Given the moral resonance that this figure currently inheres, the tension is broadly between the particular and the general: animated ethnographic studies that defamiliarize children's lifeworlds and research that emphasizes a singular normative 'ideal' with which to comparatively measure their lives. While this ambiguity has been variously engaged (Boyden, 1997; Burman, 2008; James, 2010; Nieuwenhuys, 2010; Qvortrup et al., 2009; Wells, 2009), in this book I emphasize what these authors have overlooked, namely, the more historically situated analytic of postcolonial modernity. This analytic, I argue, disentangles both the authoritative web of 'cultural' representations and the truth effects of policy discourse, revealing these apparently opposite formulations as complexly interconnected through the workings of the state, the market and a global humanitarianism.

# 1

## Re-forming Lives: The Child on the Street and the ‘Street Child’

In the early nineties, Calcutta, a city that has long been identified with the charity of Mother Teresa, began to experience a radically different kind of philanthropic affect. Elaborating itself through newer NGOs and charity organizations, this new secular humanitarianism gathered around a figure who was previously noticed, but not spectralized or ‘recognized’, as a singular target of reform. This was the figure of the ‘street child’. In post-partition Calcutta, as the city dealt with unprecedented population shock waves of refugees and rural migrants,<sup>1</sup> poor children on the street became a common sight. But they only helped produce the general picture of desperate poverty, a displaced postcolonial humanity struggling for survival in the modernist city. They were not unique or visible as a singular and special category of a problem that needed fixing. As an indistinct part of the mass of the poor, they gradually served as metonyms for the city’s decline and its inability to keep pace with the increased aestheticization and modernization in other Indian metropolises, thus effectively reinforcing Calcutta’s commonplace conflation with charity and decay (Hutnyk, 1996). However, within this generic conflation, in the nineties newer shifts in technologies of acting upon the poor had started emerging. These shifts, which had strong linkages with a transnational, ‘development’ form of governmentality, incipiently emerged against a waning backdrop of Marxist dreams of a revolutionary society and came to redefine the city’s relationship with its children on the street. Within this, such children were rapidly reassembled in the new ‘population’ type we call ‘street children’.

Although in a general sense the hyper-visibility of the street child can be traced to the global ratification of the UNCRC in 1989,<sup>2</sup> it was acutely magnified in Calcutta, which was embarrassingly branded as

the Indian city with the 'largest number of street children'. As a build-up to this Convention, unprecedented attention began to be paid to issues concerning children and more specifically to the daily plight of poor children in the non-west (Agnelli, 1986). Increased international media coverage painted a dismal portrait of the latter's everyday lives, with the street child representing a particularly stark figure that served as a moral foothold within this global effort to standardize children's material circumstances through an emerging discourse on children's rights. UN conventions (except when they are viewed as interfering in issues of national security) are somewhat peripheral to the world of domestic politics in India, and the Indian media, in keeping with this sentiment, paid minimal attention to this Convention. But, unlike UN conventions of the past, the critical significance of this one lay in the ways it marked the moment of a crucial domestic policy shift in imagining reform for marginalized children. Its workings, though less visible in the early nineties because of their being restricted to NGOs, began, by the end of the decade, to coincide with the Indian state's new and more systemic articulation that universal and compulsory schooling constitutes an ideal future for these and all poor children. The nineties were dominated by international donors, government-aid agencies in the US and Europe and multilateral funding institutions vying to find perfect solutions to transform the lives of street children. During this period, Calcutta witnessed a formidable rise in the number of NGOs that worked with this population, with each of these organizations carving out their turf geographically, competing for funds through marking the need for their services by inflating the numbers served. This meant that estimates of the number of street children in the city grew phenomenally, and this statistical and non-governmental pressure managed to draw the existing Communist government into the new discourse of concern and care.<sup>3</sup> The need to address this issue generated a previously unseen willingness to work with these local organizations as well as international donors to improve the plight of these children. The Ministry of Social Welfare estimated that of the 10.9 million persons living in the city in 1992, 75,000 to about 200,000 consisted of children living on its streets.<sup>4</sup>

The counting of street children as a distinct category and the rapid ascendance of this 'population' as an object of care were evidenced in the setting up of the City Level Programme of Action (CLPOA) in 1995, with the Municipal Corporation of Calcutta providing office space in its main building in Chowringhee to house this initiative. Viewed as 'a joint effort by both government and non-government agencies to

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coordinate programs that favour poor children and promote child-rights oriented policies' (UNICEF, 2003), this coalition of forty-three street children's organizations was the first of its kind in the city. Its emergence marked a shift from an earlier moment of government suspicion of NGO efforts to a recognition of the need for their active involvement. Estimated to be working with 32,000 of the city's 200,000 street children, the CLPOA consciously organized itself as a 'city' initiative by ensuring that each of its NGOs worked in a distinct, and not overlapping, area of Calcutta. The CLPOA worked systematically, using a new language of 'increasing the capacities of local organizations', to create a comparable similarity in the programmes undertaken by the forty-three organizations in its network. It thereby established, for the first time in Calcutta's history, an incipient citywide imagination of reform for street and working children.

Coordinated by a central body, whose members included the Calcutta Municipal Corporation, the sectoral government departments (for education, health, social welfare and labour) of the West Bengal state government, the police department, Human Rights Commission, Juvenile Welfare Board and UNICEF (UNICEF, 2003), the CLPOA marked a shift in the direction of what Sarah White (1999) has, in the context of Bangladesh, referred to as the move from an 'established rhetoric of opposition between State and NGOs' to a relationship of 'complementarity and common interest'. According to White, this is part of a more generalized trend actively promoted by international funding and regulatory agencies, like the World Bank, to place NGO activities on a favourable scale with those of the state and to increasingly use these organizations to improve and compete against the government's delivery of services. The CLPOA appeared to reflect this trend quite strongly given that it had been set up by UNICEF and was housed by the Calcutta Municipal Corporation, at the request of the Director for Social Welfare for the government of West Bengal, with an express mandate to highlight 'children's issues' in all government departments, including the police. However, because it also worked to secure a new 'population' of children, namely 'street children', CLPOA effectively marked more than the delivery of services. It appeared as a strategy to locally stabilize and reproduce the multiple circuits of persons, ideas and institutions linked to the implementation of a larger transnational reform effort around a new imagination of children's rights. The powerful involvement of the state in CLPOA efforts related to the protection, promotion and dissemination of children's rights disclosed that the deployment of

this language was intimately linked to a new, complementary relationship between NGOs and the state, that is, a new form of governmentality. The liaison officer appointed by the CLPOA reported directly to the city's mayor, and the first person to hold this position saw her responsibilities as twofold: the first was specifically tied to sensitizing the media and the state (especially the police) to issues that affected these children, and the second was to devise a uniform curriculum that would allow for these children to be mainstreamed into the city's municipal schools.

CINI-ASHA,<sup>5</sup> the most powerful NGO in this coalition, was responsible for central Calcutta, where it managed twenty centres, several of which, like the Sealdah Station shelter, were both 'drop-in centres' and 'night shelters'. Started in 1989, the Sealdah shelter was CINI-ASHA's first intervention with street children,<sup>6</sup> and this residential site, located on a railway platform in one of the city's busiest railway stations,<sup>7</sup> delivered services exclusively for boys. In addition to literacy instruction, the site also provided shelter, food, rudimentary health services, counselling services, storage lockers and facilities for bathing. It served as the main laboratory for generating and consolidating new techniques of reform and development of these children. Processes of record keeping, formulation of daily routines, shifting regulations of what the children were permitted to do while outside the shelter, pedagogic material for literacy instruction and the creation of case histories were developed as techniques at Sealdah and then made available through different, but complementary, circuits that extended towards other similar local initiatives as well as came to influence the growing matrix of a global imagination of street children's programmes. While this 'local' site on the platform of the station grounded and generated its own globality, it remained open to various shifts in the global arena of street child politics. These shifts often made themselves known at this local level through changed requirements in measuring the success of the site's interventions with these children. Unlike the dreariness usually associated with record keeping, what was remarkable about these nervously drafted reports and the loop of information collection they triggered between the Sealdah centre, the CINI-ASHA office and the donor agency was how this reciprocal process fit existing initiatives on the station platform while generating new areas of concern. This documentation, because it relied primarily on a reporting through numbers, continually deployed 'street child' as an obvious category to describe these children. They had become a reified population.

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This category of the 'street child' – coined in the seventies to replace the earlier colonial/disciplinary state's 'tactless' naming of children found on the streets as vagrants, runaways or urchins – carried within its new philanthropic apparatus an additional moral charge of reframing such children through the discourse of victims and victimhood, as primarily abject subjects. This reframing included assumptions that these children's psychosocial maladjustment and neglect were a result of their origins being located in the twin conditions of their lives on the street and the absence of a familial environment. Attempts to define who counted as a 'street child' often misrecognized all children present on the street as 'street children', sensationalizing their lives in order to corner the required programmatic resources (Connolly and Ennew, 1996). Even though increased academic and policy research pointed to the relationships that a large majority of these children had with their families and extended kin,<sup>8</sup> the continued recognition of this population within newly minted categories of 'moral panic' (Krinsky, 2008), like 'Children in Especially Difficult Circumstances' – a category that originally also covered children affected by organized violence and disasters – meant that the absence of family and the traumatic effects this signified continued to function as the dominant narrative on these lives. These homogenizing and hegemonic assumptions also exercised a certain deterministic weight, that is, the spirit of reform under which these programmes worked required the ability to stabilize these children's lives around a protection-cum-disciplinary axis, whose challenge lay in securing lasting marks of identification on their target population.

At Sealdah, a series of practices – the ways in which information was collected when a new boy joined the site, programmatic interventions that did not include children's families within its imagination, the dramatization of current lives through skits and rallies to raise 'awareness' amongst a general public – directly involved and affected the children. Through these practices, they became aware of the ways the 'street child' category worked to frame their lives, while they simultaneously contested this categorization. Unlike the precise surety consolidated through the operation of statistics and numbers in formal documentation, these practices continually disclosed a more complex fact about the everyday functioning of the category street children. This was its constant accommodation of the reality that *for these children* the very category of 'street child' itself functioned as a powerful but profoundly



imprecise and incomplete reading of their lives. Let us then look at these practices more closely.

### **A skit in/out of its performance**

In early 1995, the global emphasis on community-based models of AIDS prevention was beginning to modify the existing contours of health provision amongst street children. The disease was assumed to threaten street children as a 'population', since their individual behaviours put them at high risk of transmitting the virus. As a result, there was widespread mobilization of these children as 'peer educators' by local NGOs. The pedagogic strategies they were assigned included scripting and acting out short skits that highlighted 'good practices', performed in various public locations across Calcutta and usually attracting large crowds. A few children would enact the skit, while others would hold up the banner of the NGO – CINI-ASHA in this case – as the backdrop of a temporary stage on the sidewalk. The NGO staff often developed the stories that these skits dramatized, and the children brought in the required authenticity by drafting dialogues to generate curiosity, laughter and a sense of identification with the issue at hand.

Most skits were variations of a storyline that had a young 'street child' as its main protagonist and traced this child's fall into 'bad company'. The latter was primarily signified through a narrative cohering around the child's penchant for unprotected sex (with multiple partners) as well as his regular ganja use and needle sharing. The particular skit I saw performed on the open grounds of the Calcutta Book Fair revolved around two 'street children' who have AIDS but are unaware of the deadliness of the disease, both in its ability to kill them and in their own role as carriers of the virus. The 'reformist' moral telos of the play consisted of their immersion within an NGO programme that eventually makes them realize the 'truth' about AIDS, after which they decide to start a campaign to inform their peers about the disease and how it can be prevented. However, their plans are thwarted on the street by the 'dadas' – powerful local goons/drug traffickers – who want these children to continue taking ganja. These 'dadas', within street children discourse, constituted the criminal types or the problematic non-citizen subjects, from whom these children need to be rescued. Within the narrative of the play, it is the NGO and the police who serve as equal agents of 'good governance' to save these children from this more pervasive contamination. The story ended with the children being doubly 'rescued' from this darkness: firstly, in an empirical and institutional sense by an NGO that offers to take care of them and, secondly, in a more



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comprehensive (ideologically) transformative sense through their subsequent realization that in 'education' lies a bright, safe and normal future. Idealizations of citizenship involving 'information', 'education' and 'awareness of one's rights' served to differentiate younger street children from the older youth on the streets, and the subsequent creation of new identities was indexed by children learning to recognize the previously not so obvious 'dadas' as the threatening and absolute figures of otherness. After that performance at the annual Calcutta Book Fair, Shankar – a young street child of thirteen, who usually had the most significant role in the skit – turned to me and remarked quite straightforwardly, 'We are asked to act out our lives in this drama. People only come to watch us because we are street children. But the real drama is that *we are really acting out the ways people usually think of us and our lives on the street.*'

Shankar's statement provides an opening through which to discuss 'street children' both as a specific identity produced by the population category as well as the name of a more heterogeneous subjectivity that continually marks the limited nature of the category itself. The lives of children on the street are implicated in the category and yet, simultaneously, consist of a profound and boisterous laughter aimed at the category's limited reading of them. The subjection of these children to the power exerted by the NGO, which compelled them to assume the identity that the category provided, was seldom a straightforward exercise at the Sealdah site. Shankar's 'acting out' his life as a 'street child' revealed his accommodation of a particular register of recognition, while simultaneously disclosing his belief that the category provided an inadequate description of his life. Instances like the skit made him aware that children like him were categorized as belonging to a collectivity marked by loss, in which their passivity and abjection were emphasized.

The categorization of course, also put into place attendant incitements to rescue and save, which then served as the terrain on which the NGO crafted its efforts. Reforming this 'population' was often linked to a certain fixity in the ways their current lives were understood by the NGO, with the arbitrariness of the street, their proclivity for crime, their disregard for sexual norms, along with the dominant fact of their young age, all impinging on the NGO's basic working assumption of the street child as 'victim'. An awareness of this victimization, their construction as vulnerable children, circulated through routines at the site that mapped themselves on to children's bodies in an attempt to discipline and thereby transform signs of neglect into redeemable futures. Though aware that the NGO space was constituted through its ability to fix their

identities as victims and then act upon them as such, these children's subjectivities rested on a more expansive reading of their lives. While certain 'objective facts' of their lives – working on the streets in highly exploitative situations, regularly sniffing glue and scavenging – did indicate a certain precarity that is central to the idea of 'street children', their ability to set themselves apart and live beyond this frame meant that their subjectivities were seldom foreclosed by these 'objective facts'. And, as Shankar's statement makes clear, it was in the tension between a reading of them as children and what the children understood as *their* efforts to create community and craft lives in the city that this 'politics of saving' was actualized.

### **The case of a 'case file'**

For the children, the most emblematic iteration of the category's conventional understanding of their lives took place when they joined the shelter and their case-history was required to be recorded. Despite the staff's awareness of the complexities of the kinship networks, both fictional and real, which were maintained and cultivated by these children, a new child's entry at the site often served as a moment when the category functioned as an empty sign to broadly accommodate the child on the street as 'abandoned'.<sup>9</sup> Most children recounted that in the initial interview, they highlighted tragic and painful events in their lives. In some cases, these were related to the reasons they left home but, more often, to experiences on the street. When it came to the reasons they were on the street, the children believed that they could provide family poverty as an adequate cause for their need to earn an income. However, given that most of them had begun earning quite early in life while living at home, their articulation of the reasons they left was often tied to a traumatic event that reinforced assumptions about their victimization.

Sanjib Mandal, a child of about eight, recounted that when his mother got TB and was unable to work, he dropped out of school and found employment as domestic help. He continued to stay at home and work for the next three years until his employer's physical abuse forced him to run away. He found his way to the station with the help of another child who commuted daily from Bagha Jatin to Sealdah. Jahed, who appeared to be the same age as Sanjib, recounted that he began working when he was four years of age, trying to earn some extra money for his mother to help take care of his two younger siblings. When a little older, his uncle found him employment at a tailoring shop, where he earned a slightly better wage. His father, who usually spent most of the

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income, subsequently abandoned his mother, which prompted Jahed to leave Budge-Budge and come to Sealdah in search of higher paid work.

In each of these cases, there appears to be a traumatic incident – a beating in the first case and a father's abandonment in the second – which caused these children to leave home. But most often, this decision to leave did not necessarily mean that they had abandoned their families; in fact, they continued to maintain very close ties. Similar to Jahed starting work at a young age to help his mother look after his younger siblings, most of the boys' earnings helped pay for family members' medical bills, school education and the like, generating extra money for unexpected events as well as more mundane expenses. However, for their initial interviews, the boys knew not to recount their enduring family ties but instead to highlight the event that caused them to leave. The ritual of new children's entry into a street children's organization usually entailed their recounting the story of their lives thus far. Both their inability to fill out a form and the field staff's efforts in making new entrants feel at ease instituted this procedural, though affective, moment. The children's negotiation involved their crafting narratives to fit a past reading of their lives as 'street children' that the staff would find acceptable. For new entrants, the staff's tacit approval of their pasts was also a way of establishing a relationship with them. The boys realized the importance of this and, therefore, of getting their stories right.

As a child of fifteen living at the shelter, Rajesh bore all the markers of a 'street child': he appeared not to have any family ties; he earned on the street and had unambiguous signs of neglect on his body. His narration of his life contained all the elements that would mirror the trajectory of a typical street child, and would, therefore, facilitate categorizing him as 'victimized', except for two facts. One, he regularly visited his mother and gave her the money he earned, and two, he had left home because he was bored of staying there, a different order of reality and affect that has little room in the prevailing categorization of these children. Talking about leaving home and his entry at the shelter, Rajesh said,

I was born in Mechua. My parents and younger brother live at home, and I also have two sisters who are now married. I did not fight with my parents and leave. I just did not like staying at home anymore; I got bored and so I left. I came to Sealdah and stayed at the market for one year. I used to drink a lot of alcohol and smoke ganja while there. That's where I also met Mohammad, who told me about the

school. I decided to check it out. When I first came here, Auntie asked me to tell her about my life on the streets. I told her about the time I had spent at the market and how I now wanted to give up that life. When she asked me about my home life, I did not tell her that I had run away because I was bored. Instead, I said that my father was not able to work because of an injury and that my mother wanted me to earn money to support the family.

In his case file, Rajesh's story was more conventional. Like most of the children at the shelter, he explicitly mentioned that he was earning money for his family. He fictionalized his father's illness and his mother requiring him to earn, crafting these as the reasons he had left home. Rajesh knew that being 'bored at home' would not be an acceptable statement in the logic of the case file and would be considered awkward. When asked why he felt the need to construct this particular story, Rajesh said he wanted to gain entry into the shelter. It might have been Mohammad, the child who introduced him to the shelter, who coached him on how to respond.<sup>10</sup> Or it may have been Rajesh himself who deciphered the answer to the riddle of 'acceptance'. Either way, for these children, a persistent sensing of the symbolic and affective order was key to their inhabitation of the category called 'street child'. Rajesh had learnt that it required a credible narration of neglect. The children's narratives are considered rational only when there is an assumption of some kind of abandonment that serves as the cause for their life on the streets. The interview was a performative space, an open invitation to narrate, while at the same time its strict economy signalled to the child that only certain narratives were admissible if the acceptance of the field staff was to be gained. The moment was framed within a particular affect that firmly gestured that only predictable recreations of 'past lives' and a playing down of existing ties of kinship would be allowed. All of these effectively maintained what Foucault has discussed as an 'effect of finalization relative to an object' (Rabinow, 1984), a certain transparency within which the premeditated categorization of them as 'street children' got reinforced.

### **The field staff**

But what about the interviewers themselves, the ones who navigated the uncertain waters of childhood to produce the case file? Working-class poor themselves, with a fragile sliver of schooling as their cultural capital, how did they come to occupy this role of subaltern mechanics of the street children machinery of the global affect economy? It

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appeared that the sense of neglect generated by the initial interview allowed the staff to ease into and identify with the crucial ameliorative role they were being asked to exercise in these lives. One of the staff persons at the site described her work, stating,

I find that the children who listen to me most easily are the ones with whom I have been able to establish a relationship that is much more than my being a staff person at the site. They think of me as family and are happy to see me every day. They come to the gate of the station every morning, wait for me to arrive and walk with me to the site at the end of the platform. It's a way, I think, they like to let others at the station know that they have a special place in my life. That they have someone who specially cares for them.

This 'special' role that the staff person viewed herself as performing in these lives was to some extent premised on filling an emotional need that the children's victimization was viewed as having naturalized. The staff person secured the necessity of her presence less as a professional or an 'expert' trained to work with this population and more as 'family'. Her remarking on the public affection and performativity of the boys in their meeting her by the gate of the station and walking with her to the site reinforced this sentimental attachment. In addition, more often than not, it helped to further stabilize these children's identities as 'abandoned'. This view was supported, though differently asserted, in another staff person's comment that these children were like *norom mati* or soft clay. He said,

When the boys first come to us they are extremely 'raw' like *norom mati*, and we have to spend the first few months not being too strict with them, but rather letting them know that we are always available for them. The first interview lets us know what has happened in their lives so far and allows us to work towards improving their lives. We feel that we are doing this for their own good, just like their parents might have if they were from regular families.

Being available for the child required the staff to take the information gathered from the initial interview as a nodal point that would help determine the slow plotting of a path to normativity, an improvement that simultaneously framed these children's past and current predicaments as lacking. Characterizing the children as '*norom mati*' additionally suggested the staff's belief that they were promoting these children's

best interests, interests that the children could not as yet recognize as they came from families that were not 'regular'. The initial interview then appeared to do more than just serve as the empirical first point of contact between the child and the staff. As a performance repeated with each enrolment, it helped to make the NGO indispensable for the child and enabled the children to create affective bonds with individual staff members. The boys not being from 'regular families' served to construct the ties that a majority of children continued to maintain with their families as non-threatening, as these ties symbolized continued exploitation that the staff sought to limit through improving these children's lives. The staff's investment in their quasi-parental role appeared to be secured through this particular construction of the children's families.

But often in informal conversations, the staff's own lower-middle-class backgrounds were disclosed in their more empathetic reading of the rural poor. They acknowledged the hardship of rural peasants' lives as responsible for the neglected state of their children, while also lamenting the peasants' unwillingness to change. This latter reading appeared to be linked to anxieties that were more autobiographical. Several of the field staff, often at the bottom of the NGO hierarchy, were either first- or second-generation migrants to the city who believed that they had, through hard work and sacrifice, been able to gain this prized job. Unlike the more elite staff members, who worked at the NGO's headquarters and wrote reports as well as liaised with English-speaking international funders and visitors, the field staff had been picked for what was believed to be their 'on-the-ground' skills. The field staff recognized this as nothing more than a euphemism for their being from the working class. Their knowledge of the street was reified into a 'resource' to build informal ties with the station community in order to gain access to and retain children who roamed the station's vicinity. A close familiarity developed at the site between the staff and the children within the regime of favours exchanged, jokes shared and allowances made for occasional truancy. Amongst the field staff, the normative grid of childhood that underlay the reform work of the NGO was seldom read in terms of liberal conceptualizations of children's innocence, vulnerability and the need for their protection. Instead, the staff interpreted their mission more as the need for these children to be included within an explicitly strict and disciplinary grid that would work towards ensuring better futures for these boys. Rather than 'saving childhood', it was about bringing these children's lives in line with the hard work that their futures would require. The provision of welfare services and the disciplining of children that it necessitated was linked

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less to an abstract ideal and more to techniques through which the staff might manage these children. Ganesh, one of the most experienced field staff members, said,

Our work is to make the children more *bhadro* (respectable/civility), to make them take an interest in learning and to make them more disciplined. While at home, some have studied. But different, terrible events forced them to leave. Once on the street, they learnt various things in order to survive that have corrupted them and we want to get them to change. We want them to have future lives in which people will not be able to tell the difference between them and children from regular families.

Not being able to tell the difference between them and children from 'regular families' was the stable fantasy of improvement that the staff worked with. This was linked to a programmatic effort to have these children learn a bourgeois respectability, whose norms and sensibilities in terms of body, voice and behaviours stood in violent contrast to the corrupt dispositions learnt on the street. The instability of the street and its profound effects were viewed as capable of being transcended because as 'children' it was their temporally inscribed biological immaturity, with the vastness of futures this signified, that worked to frame their pasts as surmountable. '*Norom mati*', which powerfully governed the imagined and required transformation of these children, was an attempt to frame the antagonisms that had plagued these children's past and present lives as circumstantial, while there simultaneously circulated a recognition of the underlying class differences that had produced these circumstances, namely, their not being from 'regular' families. The desire to read this irregularity as '*norom mati*' disclosed some of the contradictions that framed civil society efforts to reform marginal children's lives in the postcolony.

The consolidation of childhood through the 'innocence' of the child has often led to an imagination of childhood as a utopian space, outside social divisions, free from sexuality, separated from adult anxieties, closer to nature and, therefore, more fluid in terms of imaginative potential (Jenkins, 1998). Several theorists have critiqued this 'innocence' as something that works less as the property of childhood than of adult desire (Rose, 1984) and empties children of their political agency, making them available to perfectly fulfil the symbolic demands made on them by adults (Kincaid, 1992), including a politics of nostalgia or a desire to recreate through children something that has never existed



(Jenkins, 1998). As I argue in several chapters of this book, in the post-colony, the fantasy of the potential uncoupling of these children from their class backgrounds through projects of disciplining them, which circulates within the current convergence of discourses on schooling, children's rights and ending child labour, has less to do with consolidating a shared understanding of 'childhood' and works more as an aspect of governmentality. The contradictory unevenness that this process of governmentality generates is not only around what Akhil Gupta (2012) has characterized as the 'production of arbitrariness' or the heightened contingency that marks such bureaucratic and state efforts. It is also about the ways in which the everyday experiences of marginal populations work to create a dense network of kinship and other social connections that partake of these governmental efforts but are seldom determined by them. The seemingly fragmented experiences of these children's everyday lives appear at one level as subjective, arbitrary and, therefore, inconsequential. However, this book employs the particularities of these children's encounters with this project of reform to help plot a more intimate story around the larger economic, social and historical forces that have shaped their lives and which create children like Shankar – a street child who without doubt is marginal but who is simultaneously able to perform his marginality and thereby lets us know that there is more going on than what meets the eye.

### **Living at the shelter and the station**

Similar to the Sealdah staff's framing of the children at the station, the ideal-typical profile of a street child that the global project of reform relies on valorizes 'victimhood', not only in order to increase the profile of this population globally (Connolly and Ennew, 1996), but more significantly, to use victimhood to substantiate their lives on the street as solitary, harsh and naturally worth giving up. At Sealdah, the technical matrix of reform efforts that read children primarily in terms of their victimization was quite typical of similar NGO reform efforts around the globe (Bornstein, 2001; Manzo, 2008; Nieuwenhuys, 2001; White, 1999). Children like Shankar, Sanjib, Jahed, Rajesh and Mohammad were aware of the different points of impact at which their identities as 'street children' were deployed by the NGO, used to build legitimacy around reform efforts and creatively enacted to solidify the impression of these children moving in a trajectory that was intrinsically better than their pasts. The children participated in this without much hesitation or ideological conflict with how their lives were portrayed

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to funders and 'white-skinned' visitors as well as in photographic and video footage. As Abbas, then ten years old, saw it,

CINI-ASHA is trying to help us with our lives on the station and we are happy to get a locker, food and other facilities. We know that to get this they require us to study for three hours a day and we enjoy this as well. As long as we are still allowed to go scavenging and make a living in the market, we don't mind all of this because it allows us to keep in touch with those we know at the station and lets them know that being at the shelter has not changed us or made us lose touch with them.

The apprehension that Abbas reveals through his desire to not 'lose touch' discloses the complex constellation of relationships that framed these children's lives, relationships that attested to their being less isolated than the category 'street child' would lead us to believe. Deconstructing assumptions around these children's victimization have been variously pursued in several existing ethnographies on street children that discuss them as a strong stable group with its own subculture (Beazley, 2003b; Davies, 2008; Fujimora et al., 2005; Kovats-Bernat 2006) and acting with a heightened degree of altruism towards one another (Swart, 1990). In addition, the biological anthropologist Catherine Panter-Brick's comparative assessment of street children's developmental indices with those of home-based children from the same social class – comprising measuring the height, weight and growth patterns of children in Brazil and Nepal – found street kids to be heavier and taller than their home-based peers. Her explanation for this is that, as competent foragers in open-air markets and part-time workers in bars and cafes, street children's access to food was better than that of their malnourished siblings (Panter-Brick and Smith, 2000). Panter-Brick (2001, 2002) also threw light on the fact that living on the streets produced no greater risk of stress-related disorders than being a poor child living at home. This was discovered through research that compared the cortisol levels of homeless street children with a sample of middle-class children in one city in Nepal and found them to be the same. In Ethiopia too, Panter-Brick found that cortisol levels of street children were similar to a matched sample of home-based children from the same socio-economic class. More recently, the Consortium for Street Children, in its publication, *State of the World's Children: Research* (de Benitez, 2011), discusses alternative understandings of street children, including considering these children as those 'for whom the street is a reference point or has a central role in their lives', or otherwise, reading them as 'child migrants' or 'street youth'. This report helps to better

locate the street in the lives of these children while not reading this as a social pathology. However, its tendency to read this population as agentic and exercising resistance through their efforts around crafting counter-cultures tells us less about the postcolonial re-inscription of sovereign subjecthood, as well as critical moments of state-directed transition that mark these lives. The latter include, in particular, the ways in which projects of national renewal and international development continually deploy these marginal children within affective registers of individual and community reform, and the children's continual negotiation, rather than avoidance, of these efforts. As Abbas's statement discloses, these reform efforts produced new boundaries as well as appeared to solicit shifts in identity and embodiment. His ability to sense that his participation in this NGO effort was more than his being able to access certain facilities and instead contained a larger effort to mobilize his hopes around the desirability and possibility of a different future linked to literacy instruction was disclosed by his contradictory need to signal his continued belonging to the station community through scavenging and his forays to the nearby wholesale market. The tensions of this conflicted awareness framed these children's inhabiting this project of reform, often producing contradictions, unevenness and an unpredictability of outcomes. As various chapters in this book



*Figure 3* "...we don't mind all this because it allows us to keep in touch with those we know at the station..."

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discuss, these children's embodied pragmatism reflects a longer history of their living with the contradictions produced by postcolonial capitalist development. This pragmatism had generated a particular constellation of socialization, reciprocal networks and individual enterprise, which both included and exceeded their immediate families and continually engaged these children. While this constellation unsettled reform efforts, it was not by any means a cohered effort at resisting reform but rather a form of dwelling in the present. What enabled this dwelling was a diverse range of real, fictitious and sentimental relationships and kinship networks that complexly coexisted and sustained these children within material conditions that tend to appear to us as abject.

### **Ambivalent engagements**

Though children on the street serve as a metonym for the city, the children at Sealdah were always keen to disclose their more rural roots. They read their lives less in terms of the travel accomplished and more by the relations preserved. With no knowledge of birthdates or physical age, they coded their pasts through relationships, mapping where they'd travelled through stories of whom they stayed with, worked for or fought with. The most crucial detail was that their current lives were an interregnum between a family they could always return to when desired and a future they were intent on creating. For a majority of the seventy children whose names were registered at the shelter, the station provided a source of income that allowed them to support their families who lived in the city's southern outskirts. Sealdah station had three main terminals: the South terminal, which housed the shelter at Platform Number 10, connected commuters – mostly domestic servants and small farmers who sold their agricultural produce at the nearby wholesale market – from Diamond Harbour, Budge-Budge, Canning and Laksmikantapur. These were the localities in the fringes of the city where several of these children's families lived, with a few of them having travelled from border districts in Bangladesh. The children's temporary separation from their families registered as part of their everyday abilities to assimilate with their surroundings and try and make a living from the networks and opportunities this made available. Developing and maintaining these networks formed part of their ordinary practices at the station and often created a bond between the children and the populations who subsisted on the platform.

At one level, Abbas's need to signal that he had 'not changed' revealed that the shelter, though physically located in the station, was

interpreted by those who lived on the platform as an exclusive space. This difference became apparent to these communities through the class backgrounds of the staff, who controlled the goings-on at the site, the frequent 'white-skinned' visitors and, more fundamentally, station commuters being denied entry into this space. By organizing its activities around the idea of a 'school', the NGO had pinned its normative horizon of reform on its ability to secure an unmistakable distinction from the communities at the station, even though they worked with their children and other similar populations of children. This was because these children were now being constructed within a universal capacity to build a different future through schooling.

But the boundaries between 'school' and platform that the staff had set in place were irrepressibly and constitutively porous, as it was widely recognized that these children would stay and be available for the NGO's reform efforts only if they were allowed to continue with the income-earning activities that they had grown used to as street children. The challenge for the staff was to accommodate these children's forays into the station, the nearby wholesale vegetable market, the street and alongside convince them of the need to further regulate their income earning and eventually give it up if they wished to avail of the opportunities that literacy, training in a trade and, ultimately, formal schooling represented. For the staff, as Ganesh's statements made clear, these continuing income-earning activities of the children served as the stubborn traces of recalcitrant pasts, when the 'different things' they had done in order 'to survive' were the 'corrupting' influences that required to be reduced with time and a gradual process of weaning. However, this translation of corruption, as a set of bad habits that the children could overcome through correct training, expressed a deep doubt about the communities that inhabited the station. These communities occupied the same spaces as these children when they were in the street, the market and the station, and what was in effect being conveyed through the staff's efforts to make these children more *bhadro* was the much-needed separation from the community that the reform project appeared to inhere.

The reform programme's reliance on its eventual ability to separate these children from their pasts, with these pasts being understood as habits rather than as populated by persons and kin, was what had given rise to Abbas's apprehension. An awareness of this site as a space that sought to secure a separation was also intricately reflected in the initial interview to gain entry, during which these children knew to highlight fragments of their lives that were linked to traumatic events.

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Foregrounding traumatic events meant a parallel effort to render incidental the material realities and kinship networks that had sustained them while on the street. They were deserving of the 'victimhood' not because of what they had endured as part of their survival on the street but more due to their presumed 'neglect' during the time spent there. But this 'neglect', for a majority of the children at the shelter, was only a temporary identification of their lives. Ricardo Lucchini (1996), discussing the 'constellation of relationships' that street children create, has found the street to be only one domain, amongst others, that the children are part of and has, therefore, analysed the category as that which functions as a delimited social reading of lives. The stories of these children's lives at Sealdah lay in this structure of difference rather than an ontology of lack that underlay the ideal-typical 'street child'.

The somewhat seamless platform community approximates what Nancy Fraser (1990) calls 'subaltern counterpublics'. Interrogating the historic limits in Habermas's construction of the 'public sphere' as a 'liberal model of the bourgeois public sphere', Fraser states that there was always a plurality of competing publics, including subaltern counterpublics, that contended with the exclusionary norms of the bourgeois public sphere. The sovereignty these children exercised as part of their identification with these counterpublics continually threatened the horizon of protection and discipline that the NGO programme sought to put in place. Although the programme was an effort to reconfigure them primarily through the vectors of biological age, that is, as 'children', what it constantly came up against was the children's own sense of adequacy. This produced in the children an ambivalent relationship with the disciplinary regimen at the site. As discussed in later chapters of this book, this ambivalence was linked to the complex ways in which their pasts as 'street children' were deployed by the NGO project of reform. However, these children did not resist reform per se, as they expressed a strong desire for the normative universe signalled by the NGO. Rather, their ambivalence was with the NGO's exclusion of other worlds. It was an iteration of their primary identification with a different set of social realities, within which the street signified opportunity and not victimhood, as revealed in the narratives of Rajesh, Sanjib and Jahed. This had, over time, produced carefully crafted capacities that relied upon and drew sustenance from the communities at the station. These boys' attachment to the counterpublics at the station was then very much a part of their history, of what had enabled their dignity and survival till now.



This ambivalence, however, unsettled reform efforts as these were predicated upon the willingness to change. This unsettling highlighted the absence of easy transitions and the stubborn refusals that usually underlie normative projects of reform. In addition, it disclosed that the category 'street child' was nothing more than a particular and limited stage in a child's life, quite unlike the formal category's interpretation of the street as both a physically permanent and psychologically enduring presence in these children's lives.

The framing of these lives within reform efforts in terms of a future anterior meant that the reform process was constitutively incapable of reading the complex inscriptions of these children's pasts, except as an individualized corruption that their earning an income early in life had produced. The technical matrix that emerged around these children was then one that deliberately built an image of a 'child' to bolster the distinctions between the children and the adults who inhabited the station, the street and the market.

There is an interesting parallel between the working of children's fiction and the world of street children's programmes. Jacqueline Rose (1984), in her book on A.J. Barrie, discusses the ways in which children's fiction sets up a world in which the adult comes before the child and builds an image of the child inside the book in order to secure the child outside who is difficult to pin down. She characterizes children's fiction as an 'impossibility' because it works as a domain in which the child is construed as the object of adult speech and is, therefore, constitutively pedagogic, providing no space for the child to articulate its desires outside of this adult-constructed 'childhood' or 'children's voice'. Similarly, programmes of reform constructed around the figure of the street child worked with an adult imagination of the child's present in order to fix them as in need of 'saving' and continually drew upon this ideal-type 'victim' even when confronted with a different reality. For these children, the only 'victimhood' around whose circumstances they unanimously concurred was if a child had never experienced a mother's love. The memories of their mothers were embedded not only in narratives but also in material artefacts, and the boys were usually keen to make both of these public knowledge. Almost all the boys at the site knew more about each other's relationship with their mothers than about the rest of the circumstances and incidents that punctuated their journey from home to the station. As the next section discusses, these real and fictive mothers were central to their self-construction, emotional strength and sense of resilience.



46 *Inhabiting 'Childhood'***A mother's love**

According to the children at Sealdah, those amongst them who found it the most difficult on the street and often turned to ganja were those who had been abandoned by their mother or those whose mother was dead. Often the boy's earnings were for his mother, and being able to draw upon this figure as a continual presence in his life meant recalling memories whose narratives were tied to the blissful remembrance of occasions when his mother had displayed her special love and affection for him. This often included food that his mother had saved and not eaten, money she had set aside to buy him a special gift, her waiting anxiously for him to return during festive occasions, nursing him back to health after a long illness or injury – all of which were etched in these boys' minds. No single incident that involved a mother's love and affection appeared to be expunged from these children's memories. These continued ties with their families, and especially their mothers, came up time and time again to contend with the formal category's reading of their lives in terms of 'abandonment' and 'neglect' and as restricted by a present that was limited to their presence on the street. In contrast to this, the children themselves utilized maternal affection as a more reliable measure of who amongst them would be able to survive the streets and gain a steady job in the informal economy. Most often, this was simply linked to whether their mothers were still alive and continued to maintain regular ties with them.

Tobias Hecht (1998), in his study on street children in North East Brazil, documents the difference between *moloqueiros* and other street kids, with the former believing that they let down their mothers and the matrifocal home because they did not financially contribute to the family. As a result, they framed their self-constructions within narratives of inferiority in relation to other 'street children' who actively continued to maintain these ties. Other authors (Beazley, 2003b; Rizzini and Butler, 2003) who have studied street children have also documented the ways in which their subcultures contain a close connection with their real or fictive mothers. For children at Sealdah, being abandoned by their mother constituted the greatest grief. A child who was on the street because his mother had run away with a new lover or had remarried, where the stepfather did not want the child to continue living at home, was often viewed by his peers as understandably less hopeful about the future and often more devious. The latter ascription was derived from the children believing that a boy with severed links to his mother had lost an ethical universe that would have served to remind him of the importance of being virtuous.

At the Sealdah shelter, Indrodeep was the most glaring example of a child who had suffered and whose future seemed bleak, given the death of his mother. Indro stood out because he was from a 'regular family', namely, his father had worked as an engineer at the Durgapur steel factory. Indro's mother had died when he was three and his father remarried soon after. He stayed with his stepmother, father and elder sister for another six years and then decided to leave home because of the routine altercations he had with his stepmother. More than the fights, it was his father's constant siding with the stepmother's point of view that hurt him deeply. A train from Durgapur brought him to Sealdah, where the station was so overwhelming that he barely explored the city beyond. When the money stolen from home was exhausted, he subsisted 'like a beggar' for a couple more weeks until he found out about the school and willingly enrolled. The staff worked hard at 'reuniting' him with his father and believed that he would be the perfect candidate for boarding school given that he had attended school until the fourth grade. But Indro's 'love for the street', his daily excursions to the market, scavenging and periodic disappearances from the shelter generated scorn from the staff and a lament from his peers. The staff's disdain was directed more at his choice of the harsh life on the streets than the life of material comfort that he could have had, while his peers bemoaned the moral degeneration that had begun to gnaw at his unsuspecting being due to the absence of a strong maternal presence in his life.

Unlike Indro, children who for a variety of reasons no longer maintained any ties with their mothers were often at pains to recall moments of their mothers' affection. Raju's mother was a domestic servant who, during her daily commute to Sealdah from Canning, met another man and left the house to live with him. She took along Raju's younger sister, who was less than a year old, while five-year-old Raju was left behind. Discussing this incident, Raju said,

I had been sent to my grandmother's house by my father, and then when I came back I found out that my mother and sister had left. My father was very sad and searched for them everywhere in his rickshaw and then decided to go back to his first wife who didn't want to take care of me. He asked me to leave the house and follow my mother to Sealdah. Once when roaming the station a young girl came up to me and said 'dada, dada' [brother, brother]. But I no longer remembered what my sister looked like and so I just smiled. It is only my mother's face that I remember well, but I have not seen her yet.

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Despite being abandoned by his mother, Raju could recall several incidents in which his mother had been affectionate towards him, including saving his hand from getting burnt while he helped her cook, being worried about his health and bringing him some food from where she worked in the city. Children's recollections of their mothers, particularly if they had been abandoned, were influenced by their wishful power of memory, by how they emphatically projected themselves on to what they remembered of their mothers. This identification with their mothers as benign reflects the ways in which mental images of an external object have been assimilated within the self or made into 'internal objects' (Klein, 1975). These 'internal objects' that link to the mental health of an individual, including the ego's capacity to cohere and interpret events around what it considers a good stable external object, worked in the case of these street children to highlight the identification of extra food and special care with their mothers and their ability to be sustained through this. To continue to be able to draw upon their mothers' love weighed heavily on the children's self-constructions, and the fictive kinship networks they formed at the station were most prized when they included an older woman's affection. Such affections were often expressed by these women cooking something special for a boy and then loudly calling out to him through the window of the 'platform school' in a conscious attempt to disrupt the instruction inside. The children often reciprocated this affection by sharing vegetables saved from a trip to the market, providing these women with money when they were in need or informing them in advance about a tip they had received on a night raid to clear all persons living on the station's platform. As ten-year-old Jehangir discussed, these fictive mothers

play a very important role in making us feel that we are special, that we are still children and are cared for. Though I visit my mother often, I miss having her around, and so Salim's mother, who lives on the platform, though not my real mother, is still a mother to me as she looks after me while I am here in the same way that she takes care of her two sons who live in this school. I am happy to share with her some of what I earn and I know that she looks out for me.

The station was a vast circulatory system that operated in terms of its own paradigms. The lives of its residents, which appeared on the surface as precarious and violent, hid a complex terrain of affection, trust, reciprocity, mutual obligation and a shared sense of cohabiting this space. For the children at the station, their moral universe rested on finding

within this complex terrain strong bonds of love and affection, of reciprocity, including keeping alive the memories of their mothers. These ties of affection exceeded the instrumentality of material survival and often worked to augment a sense of robustness and hopefulness towards the future. These affections were also intimately connected to these children's sense of ethics, framing correct and wrong actions against the loyalty owed to persons. Volatile as the station was, its adverse and conflicting influences appeared to be reconciled within an underlying reciprocal universe that was tangible as well as could invoke, when needed, a mother's affection as an ultimate test of integrity. The boys continued to identify with the station's counterpublics because they reinforced a primary ethical universe and were experienced as more real, more animated and more connected than the reformist ethic of the NGO.

The ability of a child like Shankar to simultaneously inhabit different worlds, to have his 'history' recorded as a case file at the NGO and to continually engage in gathering a community-of-belonging outside the logic of the formal project of reform discloses a more complex engagement with this new disciplinary apparatus. On the surface at least, this present moment of compulsory elementary education in India appears to mimic western modernity's chronology of material and technological progress. However, the fact that it is being played out in the distinct and contemporary political, social, cultural and economic landscape of a postcolonial modernity makes this a highly simplistic assertion and, in fact, forces us to pay attention to 'difference' as an essential component of its unfolding. This 'difference' is not that of an autarkic 'cultural' reading but is rather located within the differential workings of the colonial and postcolonial state and its construction of the child-figure.

### **Modernities and the figure of the 'child'**

Contemporary international efforts around 'reforming' childhoods in the global south largely interprets the absence of a shared imagination around 'childhood' in these ex-colonies within a discourse of 'lack' or as a historical lag. Their working with the stable fantasy of an universal normative childhood as an ethical good contains, in particular, a reading of marginalized childhoods in the global south as autonomous, non-modern identities that damagingly over-determine and thereby undermine children's inherent potential. 'Multiple childhoods', as discussed in the Introduction, does quite significantly counter the imperial energies of these projects of global 'saving': first through recognizing their universal norms as privileging a western